THE KEEFE TEAM · JLA REALTY · ALEDO, TEXAS

Buying a Home in North Texas

Most buyer guides are written for everywhere, which means they're written for nowhere. This one is for here: Fort Worth and the DFW area we work every day, Aledo, Weatherford, Parker County and the acreage in between. It's how we actually walk clients through a purchase, and what's different about buying in North Texas.



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1. Start with how you want to live, not with listings

Before you open an app, write down the life you want the house to support. How far will you drive to work and school? Do you want a neighborhood with sidewalks and a pool, or five acres and a barn? Is a one-story a must? How long do you expect to be there?

We ask these questions first because they decide which part of the county you should even be looking in. A townhome near downtown Fort Worth and a 10-acre place off FM 1189 are both "DFW," and they're completely different lives.

> **Keefe Team tip:** **The clearer you are on how you want to live, the fewer houses you'll need to see.**

2. Get pre-approved before you fall in love with anything

A pre-approval from a lender tells you what you can borrow, what your monthly payment will really look like, and what loan programs fit you (conventional, FHA, VA, USDA). In the rural parts of Parker and surrounding counties, USDA loans can apply, and VA loans matter here because so many of our neighbors have served.

A pre-approval also makes your offer real. Sellers and listing agents take an offer with a solid pre-approval letter seriously; one without it often goes to the bottom of the pile. We can introduce you to local lenders who close on time and know how acreage, wells and septic affect an appraisal.

> **Keefe Team tip:** **Get pre-approved first. It costs nothing and it's the difference between browsing and buying.**

3. Know what the numbers include

Your monthly cost is more than principal and interest. Add property taxes (rates vary by county, city and school district; Aledo ISD, Weatherford ISD and Fort Worth ISD are not the same), homeowners insurance, HOA dues if any, and, on acreage, the cost of maintaining a well, a septic system and the land itself.

If you're buying a homestead, you'll file for the homestead exemption with your county appraisal district (Parker, Tarrant and so on) after closing; it lowers your taxable value and caps how fast it can rise. If the property has an agricultural exemption, understand what it takes to keep it before you count on the lower tax bill.

> **Keefe Team tip:** **Ask us for a full monthly estimate on any house you're serious about, not just the mortgage payment.**

4. What to look at on a showing (especially on acreage)

In a neighborhood, we're looking at the roof, the foundation, the HVAC, the water heater, drainage around the house and the age of the big systems. Jennifer spent a decade in construction, so you get a contractor's read on every house, not just an agent's.

On acreage, the list gets longer: Is the water from a well or a co-op? How old is the septic and has it been pumped? Where does the property drain in a hard rain? What's the fencing like, and does the deed or an HOA restrict horses, barns or a shop? Is there a survey, and does the fence match it? Can you get a trailer in and out?

> **Keefe Team tip:** **Tour a property picturing the worst week of Texas weather, not just the sunny day you saw it.**

5. Writing an offer that wins without overpaying

Texas uses a standard TREC contract. The pieces that matter most are price, the option period (a short window, usually a few days, where you can walk away for any reason for a small fee), the earnest money, the closing date, and what the seller agrees to repair or credit.

We'll pull recent sales for the exact area, show you what comparable homes actually closed for, and build an offer that's competitive without leaving money on the table. In a multiple-offer situation, terms often win over price: a clean inspection timeline, a flexible closing date, or a larger option fee can carry the day.

> **Keefe Team tip:** **The best offer isn't always the highest one. It's the one the seller trusts to close.**

6. The option period: inspect everything

Once you're under contract, the option period is your time to inspect. We recommend a licensed general inspector, and on acreage, separate well and septic inspections, plus a termite (WDI) report. On older homes, a foundation specialist is worth the call.

The inspection isn't pass/fail. It's a list. We go through it together, separate what matters (roof, foundation, electrical, plumbing, septic) from what doesn't (a sticky door), and negotiate repairs or credits where it makes sense.

> **Keefe Team tip:** **Spend a few hundred dollars on inspections to avoid a few thousand in surprises.**

7. Appraisal, title and the paperwork in between

Your lender orders an appraisal to confirm the house is worth the loan. The title company researches the property's history to make sure the seller can actually convey clean title, and issues title insurance to protect you. You'll see a survey (or a new one gets ordered), the seller's disclosure, and any HOA documents.

Our job during this stretch is to keep the lender, the title company, the seller's agent and you all moving toward the same closing date, and to flag anything that could delay it before it does.

> **Keefe Team tip:** **Don't make big purchases, open new credit or change jobs between contract and closing. Lenders re-check.**

8. Closing day

A few days before closing you'll get the Closing Disclosure showing your final numbers. Review it against your loan estimate. On closing day you'll sign at the title company, bring your funds by wire or cashier's check, and once the lender funds, you get the keys.

Then one more thing, because we're the Keefe Team: our 16-foot enclosed trailer is yours for up to 7 days to move in. Just reserve your dates before closing.

> **Keefe Team tip:** **Keep a few days of essentials, medications and important papers with you on moving day.**

After you close

File your homestead exemption with your county appraisal district. Set up utilities and, on acreage, learn your well and septic maintenance schedule. Change the locks. And call us with any question, any time. We're still your agents after the sale.

Questions we hear most

How much do I need for a down payment?

It depends on the loan. VA loans can be zero down for eligible veterans, USDA can be zero down in eligible rural areas, FHA is as low as 3.5%, and conventional loans start around 3–5%. Plan separately for closing costs, usually 2–3% of the price, and for inspections and moving.

Does getting pre-approved hurt my credit?

A mortgage credit pull is a small, temporary dip, and multiple mortgage inquiries within a short window count as one. Getting pre-approved is far less costly than making an offer you can't back up.

What's an option period?

A negotiated number of days after the contract is signed during which you can terminate for any reason and keep your earnest money. You pay a small option fee for that right. It's when inspections happen.

Who pays the buyer's agent?

That's set out in the buyer representation agreement we sign before we start showing homes, and it's often negotiated as part of the offer. We'll walk you through it before you commit to anything.

Ready to start? Tell us how you want to live and we'll help you find the place that supports it.

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